

# HEROES III

OF MIGHT AND MAGIC®



## Refuge Town

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### Credits:

- **Yuya Noboru:** Author & designer of the mod (*myself*).
- **VCMI Forum:** Various helps & feedbacks, noticeably Misiokles, Macron1 & Fabrice Tierciel.
- **Various modders:** WoG Team (*Hell Steed & Nightmares*), Andruids (*Cutthroats*), Nieznany (*Overcomer*), Astaroth (*Thaumaturge*), Unknown (*Bowman*), Ben Yan (*Placeholder assets*).
- **Impact Soundworks:** Refuge's main theme.



## I) Lore

In the turbulent world of Enroth, as wars ravage the lands and kingdoms fall to ruin, there exists a faction born not of conquest, but of survival. Refuge, as they came to be known, emerged from the ashes of destruction.

The origins of Refuge are shrouded in tragedy. As the once-great civilizations of Enroth crumbled under the weight of war, countless beings found themselves displaced, their homes destroyed and their lives shattered. From humble peasants to powerful wizards, from noble knights to fearsome beasts, all sought refuge from the chaos that engulfed the world.

Led by visionaries who saw hope where others saw despair, Refuge became a sanctuary for the displaced and downtrodden. Inside Refuge, former enemies set aside their differences, united by a common desire for peace.

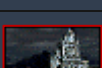
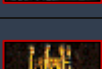
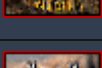
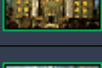
The heart of Refuge is a sprawling network of makeshift settlements, hidden deep within the forests, mountains, and desolate plains of Enroth. Here, creatures of all kinds come together, sharing their knowledge, skills, and resources in a collective effort to survive and thrive in a world torn apart by strife.

At the forefront of Refuge's struggle for survival are the enchanters, individuals gifted with extraordinary magical abilities. They harness the latent energies of the land, weaving powerful spells to protect their allies and fend off threats.

Alongside the enchanters are the wanderers, skilled warriors and survivalists who roam the wilderness, scavenging for supplies and defending the fragile communities of Refuge from marauding bands and monstrous beasts. Masters of the hunt and the art of war, the wanderers embody the resilience and resourcefulness of their faction.

Though Refuge may lack the grandeur and power of the mighty empires that once ruled Enroth, its strength lies in the unity and determination of its people. Bound together by bonds forged in the crucible of adversity, they stand as a testament to the indomitable spirit of those who refuse to surrender to despair, determined to carve out a new future from the ruins of the past.

### Relation with other factions

|                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  | Though Castle offers sanctuary to Refuge in times of need, it fears that their presence could disrupt the established order. Angels are deeply concerned about Refuge's pact with Ahrimans, but Zealots sympathize with Enchanters.                                                                                                                                                        |
|  | Rampart's prioritization of homeland preservation may lead to conflicts over resources and territory. Elves' empathy for Sharpshooters pales in comparison to the visceral hatred that Unicorns hold towards Nightmares.                                                                                                                                                                   |
|  | While initially cautious, Tower recognizes the value of Refuge's diverse population and may offer them protection and knowledge in exchange for cooperation and assistance in their magical research. They both share affinity towards golems.                                                                                                                                             |
|  | Refuge rejects Inferno's chaotic nature, viewing it as a threat to its quest for peace. On the other side, Inferno respects Refuge's alliance with Nightmares and Ahrimans. Both factions remain vigilant against potential conflicts and tend to avoid them.                                                                                                                              |
|  | The undead legion of Necropolis sees the scattered communities of Refuge as sources of fresh corpses for their armies. Meanwhile, Refuge defines Necropolis as harbingers of death and despair. Their fundamental differences in values lead to conflict and mistrust.                                                                                                                     |
|  | Refuge is aware of Dungeon's deceitful nature and rejects its dark machinations, viewing them as malevolent forces that must be opposed. Dungeon sees Refuge as a threat to their plans that needs to be eliminated. Their conflicting ideologies and goals fuel a deep-seated animosity that has always led them down a path of war and destruction. Both factions are unable to coexist. |
|  | Stronghold views Refuge as a resource to fuel their expansionist ambitions. Tensions between the two factions are inevitable due to differing ideologies, leading to clashes over territory and scarce resources.                                                                                                                                                                          |
|  | Both share a deep bond born from their mutual quest for peace and understand the challenges of adversity, fostering a deep empathy and mutual respect for each other's struggles. Together, they stand as beacons of resilience and cooperation.                                                                                                                                           |
|  | Conflux and Refuge share a mutual goal of balance among forces. Together, they strive for stability and stand as guardians of equilibrium, united in their steadfast dedication to shielding the world from the chaos and ravages of discord.                                                                                                                                              |



## II) Creatures

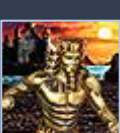
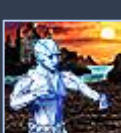
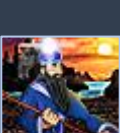
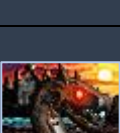
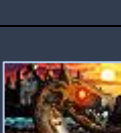
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| <b>Overcomers</b><br><br><b>Makeshift Camp</b><br>Available: 18 |   | ✕ Attack 4<br>🛡 Defense 2<br>🗡 Damage 1-3<br>🩹 Health 4<br>⚡ Speed 4<br>🌱 Growth 18    | <b>Rogues</b><br><br><b>Rogue's Cavern</b><br>Available: 8       |   | ✕ Attack 8<br>🛡 Defense 3<br>🗡 Damage 2-4<br>🩹 Health 10<br>⚡ Speed 6<br>🌱 Growth 8      |
| <b>Vagabonds</b><br><br><b>Nomad's Camp</b>                     |   | ✕ Attack 8<br>🛡 Defense 7<br>🗡 Damage 2-6<br>🩹 Health 25<br>⚡ Speed 6<br>🌱 Growth      | <b>Bowmen</b><br><br><b>Watchtower</b>                           |   | ✕ Attack 10<br>🛡 Defense 10<br>🗡 Damage 8-10<br>🩹 Health 15<br>⚡ Speed 7<br>🌱 Growth     |
| <b>Gold Golems</b><br><br><b>Golem Factory</b>                  |   | ✕ Attack 11<br>🛡 Defense 12<br>🗡 Damage 10-14<br>🩹 Health 50<br>⚡ Speed 6<br>🌱 Growth  | <b>Hell Steeds</b><br><br><b>Skull Cave</b>                      |   | ✕ Attack 15<br>🛡 Defense 15<br>🗡 Damage 18-24<br>🩹 Health 100<br>⚡ Speed 8<br>🌱 Growth 4 |
| <b>Rusty Dragolems</b><br><br><b>Mercury Lake</b>              |  | ✕ Attack 19<br>🛡 Defense 27<br>🗡 Damage 40-50<br>🩹 Health 200<br>⚡ Speed 7<br>🌱 Growth | <b>Angra Mainyus</b><br><br><b>Door to Hell</b><br>Available: 1 |  | ✕ Attack 21<br>🛡 Defense 19<br>🗡 Damage 40<br>🩹 Health 180<br>⚡ Speed 10<br>🌱 Growth 2   |

### Castle

|                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                     |                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                            |                                                                                       |                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Survivors</b><br><br><b>Upg. Makeshift Camp</b><br>Available: 1544    |  | ✕ Attack 5<br>🛡 Defense 4<br>🗡 Damage 1-3<br>🩹 Health 4<br>⚡ Speed 6<br>🌱 Growth 44       | <b>Cutthroats</b><br><br><b>Upg. Rogue's Cavern</b><br>Available: 1016 |  | ✕ Attack 8<br>🛡 Defense 4<br>🗡 Damage 2-4<br>🩹 Health 10<br>⚡ Speed 8<br>🌱 Growth 16     |
| <b>Nomads</b><br><br><b>Upg. Nomad's Camp</b><br>Available: 714          |  | ✕ Attack 9<br>🛡 Defense 8<br>🗡 Damage 2-6<br>🩹 Health 30<br>⚡ Speed 7<br>🌱 Growth 14      | <b>Sharpshooters</b><br><br><b>Upg. Watchtower</b><br>Available: 408   |  | ✕ Attack 12<br>🛡 Defense 10<br>🗡 Damage 8-10<br>🩹 Health 15<br>⚡ Speed 9<br>🌱 Growth 8   |
| <b>Diamond Golems</b><br><br><b>Upg. Golem Factory</b><br>Available: 308 |  | ✕ Attack 13<br>🛡 Defense 12<br>🗡 Damage 10-14<br>🩹 Health 60<br>⚡ Speed 7<br>🌱 Growth 8   | <b>Nightmares</b><br><br><b>Upg. Skull Cave</b><br>Available: 204      |  | ✕ Attack 18<br>🛡 Defense 16<br>🗡 Damage 20-24<br>🩹 Health 110<br>⚡ Speed 9<br>🌱 Growth 4 |
| <b>Dragolems</b><br><br><b>Upg. Mercury Lake</b><br>Available: 0         |  | ✕ Attack 24<br>🛡 Defense 32<br>🗡 Damage 40-50<br>🩹 Health 300<br>⚡ Speed 11<br>🌱 Growth 2 | <b>Ahrimans</b><br><br><b>Upg. Door to Hell</b><br>Available: 102      |  | ✕ Attack 28<br>🛡 Defense 26<br>🗡 Damage 40<br>🩹 Health 260<br>⚡ Speed 16<br>🌱 Growth 2   |



|                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Overcomer (level 1)</b><br>- Enchanted ( <i>Basic Slayer</i> ).                                                                                                                   | <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Survivor (level 1 Upg.)</b><br>- Enchanted ( <i>Advanced Slayer</i> ).                                                                                                                                                      |
| <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Rogue (level 2)</b><br>- Spying ( <i>constant "Visions" expert level</i> ).                                                                                                       | <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Cutthroat (level 2 Upg.)</b><br>- Spying ( <i>constant "Visions" expert level</i> ).<br>- No retaliation.                                                                                                                   |
| <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Vagabond (level 3)</b><br>- Sandwalker ( <i>ignore sand terrain penalty</i> ).                                                                                                    | <br>Ground, Melee    | <b>Nomad (level 3 Upg.)</b><br>- Sandwalker ( <i>ignore sand terrain penalty</i> ).                                                                                                                                            |
| <br>Ground, Ranged   | <b>Bowman (level 4)</b><br>- No distance penalty<br>- No wall penalty.                                                                                                               | <br>Ground, Ranged   | <b>Sharpshooter (level 4 Upg.)</b><br>- No distance penalty<br>- No wall penalty.                                                                                                                                              |
| <br>Ground, Melee   | <b>Gold Golem (level 5)</b><br>- Non-living<br>- Spell damage reduction (85%).                                                                                                       | <br>Ground, Melee   | <b>Diamond Golem (level 5 Upg.)</b><br>- Non-living<br>- Spell damage reduction (95%).                                                                                                                                         |
| <br>Ground, Ranged | <b>Thaumaturge (level 6) – Classic route</b><br>- No wall penalty.<br>- Cast mass spells every 5 round ( <i>haste, cure, bless, stone skin, air shield and bloodlust</i> ).          | <br>Ground, Ranged | <b>Enchanter (level 6 Upg.) – Classic route</b><br>- No wall penalty.<br>- Cast mass spells every 3 round ( <i>haste, cure, bless, stone skin, air shield, bloodlust, slow and weakness</i> ).                                 |
| <br>Ground, Melee  | <b>Hell Steed (level 6) – Evil route</b><br>- Breath attack ( <i>2-hex attack</i> ).<br>- Fire Shield.<br>- Immune to fire.                                                          | <br>Ground, Melee  | <b>Nightmare (level 6 Upg.) – Evil route</b><br>- Breath attack ( <i>2-hex attack</i> ).<br>- Fire Shield.<br>- Immune to fire, immune to mind.<br>- Death Stare (6%).                                                         |
| <br>Ground, Melee  | <b>Rusty Dragolem (level 7) – Classic route</b><br>- Non-living.<br>- Spell damage reduction (100%).<br>- Magic resistance (50%).<br>- Jousting ( <i>+5% dmg per hex traveled</i> ). | <br>Ground, Melee  | <b>Dragolem (level 7 Upg.) – Classic route</b><br>- Non-living.<br>- Spell damage reduction (100%).<br>- Magic resistance (50%).<br>- Jousting ( <i>+5% dmg per hex traveled</i> ).                                            |
| <br>Flying, Melee  | <b>Angra Mainyu (level 7) – Evil route</b><br>- Non-living.<br>- King ( <i>vulnerable to Slayer</i> ).<br>- First Strike.<br>- Spell after attack ( <i>Holy breaker, 100%</i> ).     | <br>Flying, Melee  | <b>Ahriman (level 7 Upg.) – Evil route</b><br>- Non-living.<br>- King ( <i>vulnerable to Slayer</i> ).<br>- First Strike.<br>- Spell after attack ( <i>Holy breaker, 100%</i> ).<br>- Spell after attack ( <i>Šīgû, 33%</i> ). |

### III) Heroes

|                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | <p>♀ <b>Aran</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Through her gentle demeanor and steadfast support, Aran fosters a sense of belonging among its inhabitants. Yet beneath her gentle exterior lies a steely resolve; Aran is not one to shy away from wielding her power to crush the enemies of her people, ensuring the safety and prosperity of those under her care.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Ice Bolt</b>: Casts Ice bolt with increased effect, based on hero level compared to the level of target unit.</p>                                                                            |
|    | <p>♂ <b>Areman</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Areman's life has been marked by grief and hardship as a nomad, wandering the unforgiving lands of Erathia. Despite his trials, he possesses an uncanny luck that has seen him through countless perilous situations. With a steadfast resolve forged in adversity, he stands ready to defy fate and carve his own path to victory.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Nomad</b>: Attack and Defense bonus to any Vagabond/Nomad for each level after 5<sup>th</sup> level.</p>                                                                       |
|    | <p>♀ <b>Aria</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Aria has never defined violence as an answer, but as a last resort. She focuses her efforts on ways to increase her kingdom revenues, and doesn't mind using her beauty as a weapon of choice to lead her allies to victory.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Estates</b>: +5% / level bonus to Estates skill.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|   | <p>♂ <b>Azar</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Abandoned in AvLee as a child and raised among unicorns, Azar's path led him to embrace druidic powers before joining Shayan's kingdom. Rumors swirl of his connection to Nightmares, born from a tragic attempt to resurrect a fallen unicorn into the door to hell, leaving a trail of dark magic in his wake.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Hell Steed</b>: Attack and Defense bonus to any Hell Steed/Nightmare for each level after 5<sup>th</sup> level.</p>                                                                                |
|  | <p>♂ <b>Bhemnesh</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Drawn to the arcane mysteries of necromancy and the intricacies of golem craftsmanship, Bhemnesh dedicates his life to unraveling the secrets that bind life and death with an insatiable curiosity and keen intellect.</p> <p> <b>Necrolem</b>: Raises killed enemy creatures into Flesh Golems.</p>                                                                                                                                                     |
|  | <p>♂ <b>Keyvan</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Once torn from his kingdom's grasp by the relentless tides of war, Keyvan found solace in the unity forged with Shayan, as they embarked on their quest to rebuild. Their bond as brothers serving as the bedrock upon which their kingdom flourishes. Most believe he can control the course of battles with a flick of his wrist.</p> <p> <b>Alkephobos</b>: Keyvan starts with the new spells Namburbi and Šigû, which he can casts at expert level.</p> |
|  | <p>♀ <b>Kiana</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Kiana's unwavering determination have made her a stalwart defender of Refuge against the darkest sorceries. She shields her allies from harm, ensuring that no enchantment can sway their resolve. However, her tyrannic attitude often leaded her to get into troubles.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Resistance</b>: +5% / level bonus to Resistance skill percentage.</p>                                                                                                                                                                      |
|  | <p>♀ <b>Leyla</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Leyla's heart burns with an unquenchable hatred for dragons, born from the tragic loss of her family to these fearsome beasts. Her journey has been a relentless pursuit of vengeance against the creatures that brought ruin to her homeland. She seeks to bring justice to those who prey upon the innocent.</p> <p>[<b>Specialty</b>] <b>Slayer</b>: Enchant army with Slayer at the start of the battle for 1 turn.</p>                                                                                                                      |



|                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | <p>♂ <b>Mahyar</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Mahyar roams the wilderness with the agility and precision of a true marksman. Raised in the shadows of oppression, he learned the ways of the bow to defend the downtrodden and strike back against tyranny.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Bowmen</b>: Attack and Defense bonus to any Bowman/Sharpshooter for each level after 5<sup>th</sup> level.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|    | <p>♀ <b>Mithra</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Hidden in woods near the land of Deyja, Mithra combines cunning and sorcery to outmaneuver her foes. Her skills in espionage and manipulation make her a formidable asset to Refuge, striking from the shadows with deadly precision.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Thaumaturge</b>: Attack and Defense bonus to any Thaumaturge/Enchanter for each level after 5<sup>th</sup> level.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|    | <p>♀ <b>Niusha</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Niusha's childhood was marked by the chains of slavery until the hand of King Shayan granted her freedom. Since then, she has served as a loyal and formidable warrior of Refuge, her loyalty matched only by her prowess in battle. With her past fueling her determination, she stands as a beacon of resilience and strength, a testament to the indomitable spirit of the freed.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Offence</b>: +5% / level bonus to Offence skill.</p>                                                                                                                          |
|   | <p>♂ <b>Reza</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Reza, forged from the very essence of magic and metal, is deeply marked by his needs to comprehend emotions of living beings, forever beyond his grasp. Tasked with meticulous craft inside the golem factory, amidst the clangor of gears and the hiss of steam, a silent longing stirs within him.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Gold Golem</b>: Attack and Defense bonus to any gold golem/Diamond golem for each level after 5<sup>th</sup> level.</p>                                                                                                                                        |
|  | <p>♂ <b>Shayan</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>In the crucible of conflict, bereft of his throne and people, Shayan's spirit remained unbroken. Fueled by a solemn vow to forge a new sanctuary for the left behind, he united others by his vision. Thus, Refuge blossomed into a beacon of hope, embodying the resilience and unity of those who refused to yield to the ravages of despair.</p> <div data-bbox="264 1234 328 1301">  </div> <p><b>Motley Army</b>: Prevents creatures within his army from being affected by negative morale.</p> |
|  | <p>♀ <b>Sierra</b> (Enchanter)</p> <p>Sierra believes that strength lies in alliances between each individual. She is known to travel from battlefields, tirelessly seeking out allies to join the cause. Her charismatic presence inspires others to embrace her kingdom, uniting diverse individuals under the banner of hope and unity.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>First Aid</b>: +5% / level bonus to First Aid skill.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|  | <p>♀ <b>Soraya</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Known as the queen of Logistics inside Refuge, Soraya leads her kingdom's nomadic tribes with unparalleled skill and foresight. With Soraya at the helm, her people move with efficiency, ready to face any challenge that lies ahead.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Logistics</b>: +5% / level bonus to Logistic skill.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|  | <p>♂ <b>Yemapel</b> (Wanderer)</p> <p>Native to Krewlord, little is known about Yemapel except for his impressive talents in military matters.</p> <p>[Specialty] <b>Armorer</b>: +5% / level bonus to Armorer skill.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |



## IV) Main concept & inspirations

Refugee Town is a new faction that takes its inspiration from Heroes III's **refugee camp**, and In the Wake of Gods Script67 (Neutral Town) by Donald X. Vaccarino, Jonas Gusafsson, Timothy Pulver, Kerill Kennedy and Samot.



This script replaces Conflux's creatures with a selection of the game's neutral creatures:

- |     |                 |   |                |
|-----|-----------------|---|----------------|
| (1) | Halflings       | → | Rogues         |
| (2) | Boars           | → | Nomads         |
| (3) | Fire Messengers | → | Air Messengers |
| (4) | Werewolves      | → | Trolls         |
| (5) | Sorceress       | → | Enchanters     |
| (6) | Hell Steeds     | → | Nightmares     |
| (7) | Gorynyches      | → | Rust Dragons   |

This is the reason why Refugee town's creature's line-up is mainly composed of neutral creatures. Their common point being their non-belonging to the other factions. For balance purposes, their growth and costs have been adjusted.

To keep them similar to their neutral counterparts, I decided to keep the original statistics and make them upgraded or not by comparing them to vanilla's creatures of same tier. However, some abilities were removed and added as "Stack experience" in WoG compatibility submod (*optional, players can enable or disable it in VCMI Launcher*).

Thus, this castle sports concepts such as nomadism, motley armies and makeshift solutions. The town also takes elements from the Mesopotamian, Sumerian and Akkadian mythologies.



## Motley army & Neutral alignment

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The idea of motley armies comes directly from Heroes III's **Vial of Life** scenario, where the player would have 3 refugee camps next to his castle, resulting in an army made of units that don't belong together.

The creatures don't seem to belong together, but their differences make them strong. Heroes of this faction can mix good and neutral-aligned creatures **without morale penalty**. Heroes Shayan has the specialty "Motley King", which prevents him from having negative morale. This allows the player to mix units in an original way without fearing bad morale.

## Middle Eastern influences

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The town adds a brand-new creature as the faction's 7<sup>th</sup> tier unit called **Angra Mainyu / Ahriman**, which is basically the oriental Lucifer (Satan). Its dwelling "**Door to Hell**" is a direct reference to the natural gas field collapsed into a cavern located in Turkmenistan which is known as the "Door to Hell" or "Gates of Hell". Geologists intentionally set it on fire to prevent the spread of methane gas, and it is thought to have been burning continuously since 1971.

In the Zoroastrianism, Ahura Mazda, the highest deity, created two spirits that will oppose each other. The first one being **Spenta Mainyu**, the holy spirit, and the other being **Angra Mainyu**, the destructive spirit. Later on, Spenta Mainyu will be replaced by Ahura Mazda to face the evil Angra Mainyu. The Middle Persian equivalent is **Ahriman**, which name is frequently written upside-down "as a sign of contempt and disgust" in the Pahlavi texts.

The special building "**Secret Cave**", that grants 10% interests of gold each week, is a reference to "**Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves**" folk tale where there is a magic cave hidden inside a mountain, the mouth of which is sealed by a huge rock. Their treasure is stored inside the secret cave. – *This was inspired by the fact of having Rogues as tier 1 unit.*

Rogues and Nomads, which are both vanilla's creatures, also seems to have these kinds of influences (*since at least Heroes of Might & Magic II*). This reminded me of Heroes II's Genie which was one of my favorite units of the game, that inspired me to create Refugee's special unit "**Daeva**" that is summoned by the grail during a siege:

In the Gathas, the oldest texts of the Zoroastrian canon, the **Daevas** are "gods that are to be rejected". In the younger Avesta (*primary collection of religious texts of Zoroastrianism*), they are divinities that promote chaos and disorder. In later tradition, they are personifications of every imaginable evil. – In the mod, the creature is a powerful djinn that can casts a lot of negative effects on its targets and his stats is similar to Armageddon's Blade dragons.

The town adds new spells to the game, such as **Nambúrbi** that increases troops morale and luck, and **Šīgû** that is the opposite and reduces morale and luck of targeted enemies. Both spells are inspired by Mesopotamian mythology.

**Nambúrbi** was a Mesopotamian prayer performed to counter-act evil fates and witchcraft. In Mesopotamian mythology, **Šīgû** are lamentations which are either complaints or expression of grief or sorrow.

Finally, the town's cities names are mostly taken from Persian and Ancient Mesopotamian cities:

1. **Persian cities**: Shahriar, Marvdasht, Kashan, Kermanshah, Gahvareh, Avland, Persepolia and Kerman.
2. **Ancient Mesopotamian cities**: Nippur, Borsippa, Eridu and Nerebtum.
3. There is also two **Persian's saint cities**, Mashhad and Qom, and Yazd's temple (*Persia*) called Atashkadeh.



**Alkephobos**, which is Keyvan's specialty that grants him with two spells that can control the morale and luck of every unit on the battlefield, is a combination of the names of the two ancient Greek gods:

- **Alke**, the spirit and personification of the abstract concept of courage and battle-strength.
- **Phobos**, the personification of fear in Greek mythology.

During the Middle Ages, passages from the *Sefer Yetzirah* (*Book of Creation*) were studied as a means to create and animate golem, although there's little in the writings of Jewish mysticism that supports this belief. In some tales, a golem could be activated by inscribing the word **Emét** (אמת, "truth") written on its forehead. Then, it could be deactivated by removing the aleph (א), thus changing the inscription with **Met** (מת, "to die").

This is where come the inspiration for the spells *Emet* (*summons golems*) and *Met* (*destroys golems*). Special building **Genizah** (גניזה) is also inspired by Jewish culture. It is a room in a synagogue which is used as a warehouse, mainly for works dealing with religious subjects written in Hebrew that had become unusable, while waiting to be buried in a cemetery. – *In the mod, the building grants additional spells to the Mage guild.*

## V) Scrapped ideas

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Because of VCMI limitations, several ideas and mechanics were scrapped and replaced by placeholder features:

- 1) **Special building "Refugee Camp"**: Works the same way as *Refugee camp dwelling* (*adventure map*) and *Dungeon's Portal of Summoning*. It works as an 8<sup>th</sup> dwelling that allows player to recruit a random creature from the game each week. – *This was replaced by special building "Stable"*.
- 2) **Nomadism abilities for Vagabonds & Nomads**: At the start of each week, the stack unit number increases or decreases (*random*). That's because I imagine nomads might want to leave to pursue their quests on their own, and others could want to join the party.
- 3) **Genizah**: In replacement of the scrapped *Refugee camp* special building, the *Genizah* was meant to grant every visiting hero all *golem-related spells* (*Emét, Met and Amád*). It was a requirement to upgrade the Golem's factory and built another scrapped building "special 4". Also, it allowed to convert stone/iron golem into gold/diamond.
- 4) **Special 4**: This special building was meant to work the same way as *Necropolis's Skeleton's transformer*. Player would sacrifice units to convert them into flesh golems. – Instead, flesh golems became *Bhemnesh's* specialty.



## VI) Changelogs

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### [16/02/2025] Version 1.25 – Feedback Patch #2

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- Updated graphics for Creatures portraits, Spells icons, Buildings Hall thumbnails, and Dwelling 3.
- Reworked graphics for following units: Dragolems, Overcomers/Survivors, and Cutthroats.
- Statistics and abilities rebalance for 7<sup>th</sup> level units (*Dragolems and Ahrimans*).
- Ahrimans: Subtle statistics rebalance, increased gold costs.
- Dragolems: Subtle statistics rebalance, jousting ability buff, replaced magic resistance ability with Catapult.
- Fixed Mithra and Mahyar specialties, and descriptions/tooltips for every hero's specialty.
- HoTA submod: Added Steel Golem to targets for both Amad and Met spells (*requires HoTA*).
- Renamed Submods for more clarity, and moved Bhemnesh from the main mod to a Submod.

### [21/08/2024 – 25/01/2025] Version 1.11 ~ 1.23 – VCMI Community Patch

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- Update to VCMI 1.6 format + Better compatibility system.
- Update Mysterious Lamp creature bank syntax to VCMI 1.6 format.
- Update minimum VCMI version required to 1.6.0 for Daeva SubMod.
- Russian translation by Anton Sergeew & Polish translation by FallainBlack.



## [21/05/2024] Version 1.1.1 – Feedbacks Patch #1

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- Few JSON fixes, building costs balance, and added to conflicting mod “Antagarich Burning Map Assets”.
- Fixed Mahyar description mentioning old unit Sagiitarii.
- Increased daeva’s transmute ability from 1% to 5%.
- Changed Thaumaturge and Enchanter damage bonus per level.
- Added WoG stackExp submod.

## [14/03/2024] Version 1.1 – Roster & Balance overhaul

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### General:

- NEW ALTERNATIVE DWELLINGS & CREATURES!
- Renamed in-game faction into “Refuge” (*previously “Refugee”*) to better fit H3-style town names.
- Wrote the background lore of the faction and the heroes backstory have been rewritten.
- Changed Refuge’s native terrain from “Dirt” to “Rough”, and main resource from “Sulfur” to “Mercury”.
- Fixed Factory Extension (horde) not increasing gold/diamond golems growth.
- Special building “Genizah” now grants +1 knowledge instead of adding spells to Mage Guild.
- Grail: Removed bonus to Magic resistance. It now increases movement points of heroes by 300.
- Reworked faction’s building tree and hall screen. Fixed dead pixels from adventure map castle sprites.

### Heroes:

- For heroes that specialize in creatures: Few changes/fixes + Improved graphics for specialty icons.
- Changed all hero’s description to fit the new written backstory.
- Reworked heroes’ secondary skills to be more coherent with vanilla heroes.
- Fixed Keyvan’s specialty now working as intended.
- Changed starting spell(s) for Mithra, Aran & Reza.
- Removed spell book for Shayan, Leyla & Soraya.
- Changed specialty for Sierra, Yemapel, Aran & Leyla.

### Units:

- BALANCE OVERHAUL for every creature (statistics, abilities & costs) + NEW ALTERNATIVE UNITS!
- Removed standalone copies of neutral units so the town uses the real vanilla ones.
- Improved Icons graphics, and created Daeva adventure map sprite.
- Reworked stack experience & increased compatibility with Wake of Gods.
- Converted vanilla’s neutral units’ dwellings to be the same as Refuge.
- Ahriman: Changed costs, buffed damage, Holy breaker now slows the target, removed magic resistance ability.
- Increased units’ tiers by 1: Rogue is now level 2, Nomad level 3, Sharpshooter level 4, G/D golems level 5.
- Enchanter and Nightmares are now both level 6, but their dwellings cannot be built at the same time.
- New creature LVL1 Overcomer / Survivor, and alternative LVL7 Rusty Dragolem / Dragolem.
- Replaced ex-LVL1U Spy with new creature “Cutthroat”. Has “No retaliation” instead of “Flying”.
- Replaced ex-LVL3 Sagittarii with new creature “Bowman”. Mostly graphics difference.
- Replaced ex-LVL5 Sorceress with new creature “Thaumaturge”, a weaker variant of Enchanter.
- Reworked sounds for Angra Mainyu & Ahrimans.
- Fixed Enchanter spells list to fit vanilla H3.
- Daeva now has 1% chance of transmuting target into Peasants (*buggy on VCM1 versions prior to v1.4.3*).



## [09/02/2024] Version 1.0 – Refugee Revamped

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### General:

- BRAND NEW VISUALS FOR TOWN-SCREEN, SIEGE-SCREEN, ADV.MAP VISUALS, ETC.!
- Updated town-related sprites to fit with the new townscreens (*Icons, portraits, etc.*).
- Reworked building tree and made few changes to buildings costs.
- Removed Dwelling 2 horde. Replaced unused building with special building “Genizah” (*works as Tower’s library*).
- Added adventure map visuals for dwellings and castle. Added sounds for adventure map dwellings.
- **Spell:** Increased spell points cost of ‘Met’. Fixed all spells description. New spell Amad (*resurrection for Golems*).
- Fixed ‘Holy Breaker’ ability not stacking. Fixed & improved WoG support submod (*Stack Experience*).
- Added 2 submods called “reversion” that allows to convert Refugee creatures into vanilla/WoG neutral counterpart.
- Reworked Stack Experience for all units. Fixed neutral to refugee conversion (*both vanilla & WoG*).
- Replaced Arrow creature with Enchanter (*previously ‘Roving Enchanter’*).
- **Grail:** Removed Daeva summoning. Grants +20% magical resistance to player armies instead.
- Daeva is now a creature reward for the new creature bank, guarded with Genies & Efreets. Daeva stats reworked.
- New submod that replaces the town’s theme with a remaster of the previously used theme from versions 0.1 → 0.7.

### Heroes:

- Changed biography of Reza, Azar and Bhemnesh.
- Classes: Changed Enchanter & Wanderer primary & secondary skills gain chance. Brand new sprites visuals.
- Bhemnesh: Changed starting army. Replaced ‘Resurrection’ specialty with ‘Necrolem’ (*flesh golem necromancy*).
- Shayan: Replaced skill ‘Tactics’ with ‘Learning’. Specialty ‘Motley King’ prevent bad morale for his army.  
It also gives a bonus to wandering creatures joining the army.
- Aria: Changed secondary skill and specialty is now Estates.

### Units:

- New creature ‘Flesh Golem’, a special unit which is the specialty of Bhemnesh. Similar mechanics to WoG’s Ghost.
- Streamlined commander’s data with “vanilla” commanders. Now casts ‘Amad’ instead of ‘Namburbi’ and ‘Sigu’.
- Nerfed neutral creature Shapeshifters a little bit.
- Reworked graphics for Hell Steeds, Nightmare. Subtle improvement to Angra Mainyu & Ahriman portraits.
- Tier 6: Hell Steeds & Nightmares now hates (War)Unicorns and vice-versa. Nerfed Death stare 10 → 6.  
Removed ability to casts Curse as it will now be part of Stack Experience (*WoG feature*).
- Tier 7: Rebalanced a little statistics and costs (*mainly Angra Mainyu*). Reworked adv. Map sprites.
  - o **Removed abilities:** Self-morale +1, Self-luck +1, Reduces enemy’s luck & morale by 1.
  - o **Removed abilities:** Mind spell immunity. Casts Sorrow. Casts Misfortune.
  - o **Added abilities:** Non-living, Vulnerable to Slayer (KING2), Magic resistance (+25% / +40%).

## [17/08/2023 – 16/01/2024] Version 0.8.1 ~ 0.8.5 – VCMi Community Patch

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- Added Chinese translation (*by Rindlit*).
- Added the creatures’ Stack Experience and fixed the commander stats (*by LeoAllenHan*).
- Updated to VCMi 1.4 format & several improvements made by Fabrice (*adv. map dwellings incl. SFX, etc.*)
- Adjusted Commanders’ stats and removed ‘Can shoot’ ability (*meant to be gained through leveling*).



## [01/10/2023] Version 0.8 – Global improvement & fixes

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### General:

- Miscellaneous fixes, tweaks and upgrades. Updated changelog / readme files and optimized files & workflow.
- Removed Wake of Gods dependencies and added optional file for WoG support as a submod.
- Reverted audio .OGG files back to .MP3 to preserve audio quality that was lost during the previous conversion.
- Switched v0.1-v0.7 town's theme with the previously alternate theme (*can be manually reversed*).
- Fixed several unknown and deprecated identifiers. Fixed Hell steeds & Nightmares idle animations.
- Added several visual upgrades.
- Grail now increases all primary skills by 5, and summons a Daeva during a siege.
- Fixed resource silo not producing the additional +1 sulfur per week.
- SPECIAL1 building now produces 10% gold interest per week (*same as Rampart's treasury*).
- SPECIAL2 building now increases movement rate of any visiting hero (*same as Castle's stables*).
- SPECIAL3 building description updated to prepare for the upcoming changes.

### Heroes:

- Upgraded Heroes portraits and specialty visuals.
- Removed Areman spellbook.
- Reworked Shayan's specialty mechanics (*generate a console error but it works*).
- Fixed female/male sprites being switched for some heroes (*adv. Map & combat*).

### Spells:

- Emét: Reduced spell power.
- Met: Reduced spell power and fixed target conditions.
- New abilities: Holy Breaker (*given to Refugee's tier 7 unit*) and Dominion (*unused*).
- Reworked gain chances for Refugee's spells and Refugee's Mage Guild spells.
- Added/Updated visuals for all new spells (*even unplayable*).

### Units:

- Upgraded portraits visuals for all units and rebalanced their statistics, growth and costs.
- Hell steed: Replaced non-working "casts Firewall" ability with "casts Curse".
- Removed unit "Veteran Sharpshooter" (*ex-lvl4U*). Sharpshooter are now lvl4U and statistics are now based on the original creature. Added new creature "Sagitarrii" (*lvl4*) that can be upgraded into Sharpshooter.
- Reworked level 7 unit: Rebalanced statistics and abilities. Added brand new visuals for the creature!
- Commander now casts Sigu on enemies and Namburbi on allies instead of resurrection. Added healer ability.
- Added Stack Experience for each unit (*when WoG submod is enabled*).
- New special unit "Daeva", a powerful Djinn that is summoned by the grail during a siege.

## [17/08/2023] Version 0.5 ~ 0.7 – Made by VCMi Community

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- Updated to VCMi 1.2, and then VCMi 1.3.
- Added Tower icon, Moat spell, French/German translations, and some tweaks.
- Updated Sorceress, Dwelling4 (*adv. Map*) and siege sprites.
- Updated few townscreen buildings (*blacksmith, dwellings 1 / 1U / 6U / Grail*).
- Converted themes .MP3 to .OGG format.



## [10/06/2020] Version 0.4 – Town's rebalance and assets conversion

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### General

- Created Puzzle map and siege visuals for the faction. Replaced “Sorceresses” towers garrison by Roving Enchanters.
- Optimized files (*buildings areas & borders*). Edited Dwelling5 (*ex-dwelling4*) borders & areas.
- Added an alternate music for the town (*need to be manually set*).
- Old spell “Gottesbriefe” renamed “Šigû”, and old spell “Namburbi” (*summons golem*) renamed “Emet”.
- New offensive spell against all-type of golems called “Met”. New spell “Namburbi” increases morale and luck.

### Heroes:

- Given all heroes the ability to convert true neutral creatures into Refugee's faction (*ex: neutral gold golem can be upgraded into Refugee's gold golem*). It shouldn't cost anything to convert creatures.
- Rebalanced every Heroes starting army to make them stronger, and added description to all Heroes.
- Replaced Heroes Battle & Adv. Map visuals with new original ones.
- Changed Keyvan's specialty and added Šigû as starting spell (*in addition to the new version of Namburbi*).
- Replaced Kiana's Ballista specialty with “Resistance” and changed her starting skills.
- Replaced Shayan's specialty with a new one and his starting skills. Added a surrender discount bonus per level.

### Units:

- Replaced creature “Peasant” (*ex-lvl1*) with Rogues (*ex-lvl1U*) and added new creature “Spy” as lvl1U.
- Replaced creature “Boar” (*ex-lvl2*) with new creature Vagabond (*lvl2*).
- Reduced power multiplier of Rogue's spying ability from 3 to 2. Spies spying ability power multiplier is set to 3.
- Updated adventure map amounts of every unit based on HotA's map editor values (*for same tier creatures*).
- Rebalanced units' statistics (*Tier 1, 2, 4 & 5*) to make them more coherent with their vanilla counter parts. Units are stronger but their growths are under-average.
- Edited visuals of both lvl7 (A.M. & Ahriman) and lvl3U (*Vet. Sharpshooter*) units, and sounds of level 7 units.
- Updated creatures adventure map visuals, portraits and icons.
- Hell steeds now has the ability to cast “Fire Wall” (*12% chance*) as in WoG. [doesn't work]
- Fixed sorceress (*lvl5*) missing “shot” sounds.
- Added brand-new neutral creature “Shapeshifter”.

## [20/05/2020] Version 0.2 – New townscreens & spells

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- NEW TOWNSCREEN! Successfully replaced Cathedral's townscreens with an original one.
- New buildings: Grail, Special1 (Secret Cave).
- Animated buildings: Grail, dwelling 6 Upg., dwelling 7 and 7 Upg.
- Renamed buildings and edited resources costs and unlocking tree.
- Edited various game icons to fit the new townscreens, including creatures' portraits and background, and Mage Guild.
- Remastered town's theme.
- New spell “Namburbi”: Summon Gold golems (*expert level = Diamond golems*).
- New spell “Gottesbriefe”: Reduces LUCK & MORALE of targeted enemy (*expert = all enemy's troops*).
- Replaced Keyvan's specialty with “Namburbi” and Shayan's specialty with “Resistance”.
- LVL7 units will no longer have the ability to cast Sorrow & Misfortune after attack (*50% chance each*). Instead, they will now have the ability to cast Gottesbriefe after attack (*30% chance*). Also, it will now have the ability to cast Curse before attack (*10% chance*). Nerfed attack (-5), buffed defense (+4/+3), changed DMG 30-40 to 25-45.
- LVL3 units: Removed “ranged retaliation” and “no wall” abilities. The ability “No melee penalty” will no longer apply to un-upgraded units. Reduced speed from 7 to 5.



## VII) Miscellaneous

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Ideas that are impossible to implement right now and might need ERM scripting:

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- Add (or replace special building “stables” with) a unique building “refugee camp” (*see scrapped ideas*).
- Ability “Nomadism” for Vagabonds & Nomads: At the start of each week, the stack unit number increases or decreases randomly. That would simulate nomads wanting to leave, while others could want to join the party.
- Makes grail always summons only 1 Daeva.
- Shayan’s ability should prevents bad morale due to mixing creatures from different factions (*even evil & undead*).

### TO DO LIST for future update

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- Dragolem’s dwelling mask at center? Make it less than 4 squares? (*DefPreview*)
- New Puzzlescreen? Replace Mage Guild visuals (*townscreen*)?

However, note that right now I plan to move on other projects (*see below*) as version 1.1 is intended to be my “final” release. If there’s any major bugs unrelated to VCMI updates, I could make a patch if I’m still active on VCMI modding.

Eventually, I might work on this mod in few years when AI tools will be consistent enough.

**Other Heroes 3 projects:** As I’m writing this, I have 2 new town projects, both are evil-aligned.

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#### Dread Town

This town should feel like a mix between Necropolis and Inferno, and will be more personal and conceptual. Refuge’s Flesh golems and Shapeshifters should be part of this new faction and shall be removed from Refuge’s submod later on.

#### Pristine Town

Pristine (*or Grime*) is designed to be like an evil version of Castle, with different mechanics and roster. There are also several inspirations behind this faction, mostly Heroes 2 Knight town, ERA2’s Human Castle and VCMI’s Red Castle.